

ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

change in energy in that room when I made the commitment that KOEL will remain an engineering company," she says. "And after that magic happened, it rejuvenated the whole company and we were actually the first in the industry to get all our products certified and approved with the new emission standards."

When leaders show that they can carry teams, employees and the organisation along with them, not only does it silence the naysayers, it also brings about a more positive environment at work, which translates into performance.

When Nyrika Holkar joined Godrej Enterprises in 2017, she came with experience as a corporate lawyer in London and Mumbai. This proved to be particularly useful while negotiating the 2024 family agreement that separated the Godrej family's sprawling business interests into two groups —one led by Adi Godrej and the other by Jamshyd Godrej. Holkar, Executive Director, Godrej Enterprises Group, led the strategy and negotiation for the Godrej Enterprises Group led by Jamshyd.

She's also used her background to set up end-to-end processes for the management of commercial contracts, risk and intellectual property. Currently, Holkar is focused on reviving the furniture brand Godrej Interio. She is also a brand custodian for the group. Finding a balance between preserving the legacy of the brand while ensuring it remains relevant in an increasingly changing business landscape is tricky, but essential. That's a challenge for family enterprises across the board, more so for brands like Godrej, which are over 100 years old. "The natural inclination would be to preserve everything or to change everything. Neither of the two is very helpful," says Holkar. "One must identify the elements that are enduring and specific aspects that need to be changed," she says.

GROWING INTO LEADERSHIP

At their core, all businesses are political beings. "You have to realise that the business environment will always be political. If you push back against the old guard, they will sit up and respect you. But you have to prove yourself," says Ramachandran of ISB.

Irrespective of whether it was a fight to establish their right to be a part of the business, or almost a foregone conclusion, one thing that binds all the women across generations is the idea of stewardship and being custodians of the business. Equally important is the focused effort to increase the representation of women in the workplace. "We are carrying the legacy forward and protecting it for those who follow us," says Emami's Sureka. She has actively worked towards increasing the number of women in senior leadership roles in the company; it was only natural that her daughter Avishi joined the business a few years ago.

It can be a bit more challenging in engineering-led businesses, but there is a visible shift. "We are seeing women contribute across the industrial spectrum, from the shop floor and precision engineering to the design of complex heavy-engineering systems. But increasing representation is only the starting point," says Holkar. "The real measure of progress is whether we create the opportunities, support career pathways for women to advance into leadership, and navigate critical transitions in their professional lives. Our ambition is not simply to bring more women into manufacturing, but to enable more women to shape its future."

Ultimately, what matters is upholding the family legacy while ensuring that the business continues to grow and remain relevant. And that is the compass that continues to guide these leaders. BT

(With inputs from Krishna Gopalan and Karan Dhar)